NOTRUMP OPENINGS

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Although it is not included in the Deals you might wish to examine your and dummy's hand and make a Plan of how you would play the contract.

NOTRUMP OPENINGS

This lesson is about hands which are opened 1NT or 2NT.

In fact, those two are just part of the Balanced Hand opening hierarchy:

Points	Opening Bid
12-14	Open 1 of a suit, then rebid 1NT
15-17	Open 1NT
18-19	Open 1 of a suit, then jump in notrump
20-21	Open 2NT
22-24	Open 2♣, then rebid 2NT.
25-27	Open 2♣, then rebid 3NT.

The reason that the openings other than 1NT and 2NT are excluded from the lesson is nothing sinister, but is just so we won't have to deal with the first response to those bids at this time.

A Balanced Hand is usually defined as one which has no singleton or void, and no more than one doubleton.
Thus you only open 1NT or 2NT if your hand has one of these three distribution patterns:

4 - 3 - 3- 3	4 - 4 - 3 - 2	5 - 3 - 3 - 2

There is one more restriction that may or may not be applied.
If your hand has the 5-3-3-2 pattern some insist that the 5-card suit not be a Major suit. This is strictly a partnership agreement about which many Bridge experts disagree. For this lesson we have avoided the controversy by never having an example where Opener holds a 5-card Major suit.

Bidding after a notrump opening is probably the easiest and most accurate in all of Bridge. The reason for this is that the Opener has described his hand within such narrow borders it is usually easy for Responder to determine what the final contract should be. Therefore it is logical that the Responder becomes Captain and Chief Decision-maker.

The final contract has two parts; What suit (or NT), and How High.
The How High part is decided by Responder adding the two sets of points together and seeing where the total partnership assets fit - keeping in mind that it takes 26 points to make game in a Major suit or

in Notrump, that it takes 33 points to make a small slam and that it takes 37 points to make a Grand slam.

Here is a table showing how that plays out for a 1NT opening.

Resp Points	Opener Points			Bidding Target
	15	16	17	
8	23	24	25	Partscore
9	24	25	26	
10	25	26	27	
11	26	27	28	
12	27	28	29	Game
13	28	29	30	
14	29	30	31	
15	30	31	32	
16	31	32	33	
17	32	33	34	Slam
18	33	34	35	
19	34	35	36	
20	35	36	37	Grand
21	36	37	38	Slam
22	37	38	39	

Suppose Responder has a balanced hand and wants to keep the contract in notrump.
Responder's strategy:

- 0-8 points - pass and play 1NT since there is no game
- 9 points - invite game by bidding 2NT since game may be available
- 10 points - either invite game by bidding 2NT or bid 3NT - your judgement
- 11-15 points - bid 3NT since game should be pretty sure and there is no slam
- 16 points - invite slam by bidding 4NT since slam may be available
- 17 points - either invite slam by bidding 4NT or bid 6NT - your judgement
- 18-19 points - bid 6NT since slam should be pretty sure and there is no Grand

Opener's strategy following the response:

- 15 points - decline any invitation by passing
- 16 points - either accept or decline using best judgement
- 17 points - accept any invitation

Of course if partner opens 2NT then those numbers don't work. You have to have another pretty table to look at and another set of invite/force instructions. OR, you just have to do the math in your head right there at the Bridge table. The good news is that it's easier to do the math than to memorize the table.

That takes care of How High. Next responder has to start thinking about what suit.

The bidding priority for all bidding, not just Notrump, is:

- Best - play in a Major suit with an 8-card fit or better

- Next best - play in Notrump
- Last - play in a Minor suit

The reason that a Major fit is better than Notrump is that the suit contract will usually play one trick better for about the same number of points. Not always, but usually.

The reasons that Minor suits are last is that it takes 29 points to make the 11 trick game, and that they only count 20 points per trick anyway.

For a responder to try to find a Major suit fit, his first priority, he needs help from artificial conventions. Every Bridge player should use the Stayman convention, which is designed to locate 4-4 Major suit fits. The truth is that it is difficult to discover these 4-4 fits after a 1NT opening **UNLESS** you use Stayman. There is a lesson on the Stayman convention on BakerBridge.

Another valuable aid for Major suit fits after a 1NT opening is the Jacoby Transfer. Perhaps not absolutely necessary like Stayman, Transfers certainly make a big improvement in your bidding. There is a Jacoby Transfer lesson on BakerBridge also.

Since you may not yet play Stayman or Transfers, neither of them are used in any of the example Deals.
Stayman is avoided simply by never giving Responder a 4-card Major suit.
Jacoby Transfers are avoided by providing a workaround (inferior) method for Responder to handle 5-card Majors.

25 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 2NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦3

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥2

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 7 4 ♥ A Q 8 5 ♦ Q 7 4 ♣ Q J 6	
♠ 8 5 2 ♥ J ♦ A 10 9 3 2 ♣ A 5 4 3		♠ Q J 10 6 ♥ 10 9 6 3 2 ♦ J 8 ♣ K 8
	♠ K 9 3 ♥ K 7 4 ♦ K 6 5 ♣ 10 9 7 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2NT

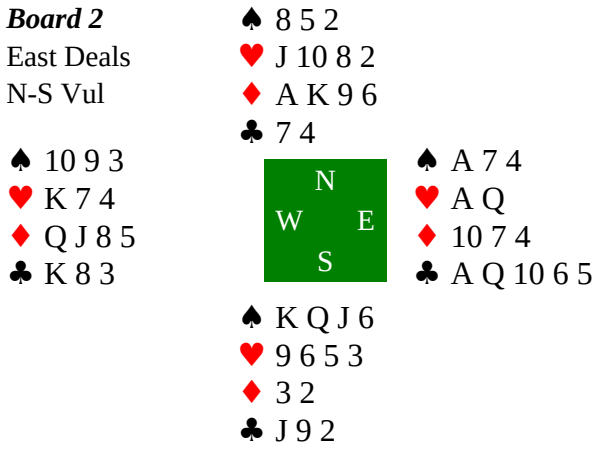
All Pass

2NT by North
Lead: ♠Q

With 4-3-3-3 distribution and 15 points this hand qualifies for a 1NT opening. You bid 1NT andpartner raises to 2NT.

Partner's 2NT bid invites you to bid 3NT if you are at the top of your 15-17 point range. Since you have only 15 points you decline the invitation.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul



West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠K

This hand has 17 points and one of the balanced distributions. When you have a hand that meets the requirements you should open 1NT. Do not worry about the lack of a ♦ stopper, you don't have to have all the suits stopped to open 1NT. You bid 1NT and partner raises to 2NT.

You should count on partner for 9 points for his invitation. Your 17 brings the total to 26 so you bid 3NT.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 6 5 ♥ K 8 4 ♦ Q J 9 5 ♣ K 8 3	
♠ A K 2 ♥ 9 7 6 3 ♦ A 6 4 3 ♣ 7 2	N W E S	♠ 9 7 4 3 ♥ J 10 5 2 ♦ K 2 ♣ 10 6 4
	♠ Q J 10 ♥ A Q ♦ 10 8 7 ♣ A Q J 9 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♦3

Of course you open 1NT. Partner responds 2NT.

With 15 points you decline invitations, and with 17 points you accept. But with 16 you have to use your judgement. Some players will just automatically bid 3NT when they have 16 points, preferring to err on the side of boldness than to possibly miss bidding a makeable game. Others prefer to base their decision on how good the hand looks.

With all the 10s and 9s this hand is stronger than 16 points, so you bid 3NT.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 6 ♥ J 6 4 2 ♦ K J 9 7 6 5 ♣ J 3	
♠ Q J 10 5 ♥ Q 9 8 ♦ A Q 4 ♣ A 9 8		♠ A K 3 ♥ A K 7 ♦ 10 8 2 ♣ Q 10 7 5
	♠ 9 8 7 4 2 ♥ 10 5 3 ♦ 3 ♣ K 6 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	4NT	
All Pass			

4NT by West
Lead: ♥2

You open 1NT. Again. This time partner jumps to 4NT.

Partner's bid is **not** Blackwood. It is called a Quantitative 4NT and he is telling you he has a balanced 16-17 point hand. He is inviting you to bid 6NT.

With 17 you accept invitations, with 15 you decline. You have 15 so you pass.

As you see, there are 9 easy tricks and you can probably set up another. But you have no chance to make slam.